

## What is truth?

A letter from Priest Seraphim. 4<sup>th</sup> Sunday after Pentecost.

June 27/July 10, 2022

[http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter\\_2022-07-10+4th-sun-after-pentecost+what-is-truth.docx](http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-07-10+4th-sun-after-pentecost+what-is-truth.docx)

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### "Pilate saith unto him, what is truth?" John 18:38

Every question in the Scriptures must be answered, even if it appears to be a rhetorical question. Pilate's question, "What Is Truth?", is a question that we must answer correctly, or we will not be saved.

In another place, Jesus taught, "I am the way, the truth, and the life." This will tell us what is truth. It is not just that Jesus is truth; the way and the life are also truth. To live according to the way of Jesus Christ, that is, His example, is the only way of life. It is possible to have truth only when living the way of life. Truth is not a concept or a fact. Truth is a way of life, truth is to become like God.

God is true and there is no falsehood in Him. We are sometimes liars, and therefore we cannot say that the truth is complete in us. The only way to be able to answer Pilate's question, "What is truth?" is to live wholeheartedly in the truth. We learn truth by experience, and since truth is a person, we learn truth by a relationship with He who is Truth. Christians love the One who is true, and obey the One Who is true.

All Christians who love truth, that is who love Jesus Christ, must be ascetics and must work to root out of ourselves everything that is false, not only the external things we do and say, but especially our internal thoughts and predispositions and attitudes. This is the core reason why there is asceticism, and if

you wish, "rules" and commandments. The whole purpose is to become like Christ, which means we become completely true, since He is Truth.

In the Psalms, which, if you are in a monastery, you will hear every single day (and whether or not you are in a monastery you should hear every day because you should be reading the Psalms every day even if it's only two or three), the song that begins Vespers describes the spiritual life thusly: "Young lions roaring after their prey, and seeking their food from God." (Psalm 103:21) We must be as lions that are searching for our prey. And the one who provides our meal will be the truth. We are pursuing the truth from God; there is no other place to learn it.

Pilate was a pagan who knew nothing of Jesus Christ until he met Him on the day that he judged Him. His question was not a serious one. Certainly, he would have wanted to know the truth; everyone wants to know the truth in an intellectual way. But he was not willing to live in such a way that he would learn the truth.

How can we pursue the truth? I think it is in practical and spiritual ways. Everything that is practical must be for a spiritual reason. The practical things include (but "are not limited to" – there are no limits in the living out of the way of Truth!): we must say our prayers regularly, read the lives of the Saints and read the scriptures. We must fast, and not

manufacture excuses not to fast. We must come to the services much more than we desire to do. We must prepare ourselves for the Holy Mysteries as often as possible (and this should be very close to EVERY TIME we attend liturgy). These practical things are of no benefit to us unless we are pursuing the truth wholeheartedly with our whole heart and soul

and mind and strength, because the truth is God and God made us to be in him and know of him.

One could say that another way of saying “what is the truth” is to actually say “how do I become the truth?” A person “becomes” the truth by living according to He who is the Truth.

In Christ, unworthy Priest Seraphim.

This personal letter is an attempt to keep in touch. I don't know how to stay in touch in many circumstances because sometimes we haven't seen each other for a long time or see each other irregularly, but I do know how to write. It has become impossible for me to lay eyes on or greet everyone who comes to church on Sunday. If you reply to me, I'll do my best to write you soon as possible.

### **Recent stuff:**

[“Not under the law, but under grace.” The \\*energy\\* to do good.](#)

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/6og9xwEfA2g>

Homily during liturgy at our “Marshall house”, a house used for housing for parolees from Texas prisons. We mostly comment on St Pauls' epistle to the Romans, which gives use the \*reason\* and the \*energy\* to do good things, and avoid sin. It is not about rules, in is about grace, and gratitude: “For sin shall not have dominion over you: for ye are not under the law, but under grace.” “But God be thanked, that ye were the servants of sin, but ye have obeyed from the heart that form of doctrine which was delivered you.” And from the Gospel, “(He) ... Himself took our infirmities, and bare our sicknesses.” 4<sup>th</sup> Sat after Pentecost Romans 6:11-17

[The New Martyrs of the Turkish Yoke teach us how to use our freedom, against the day when we are not free.](#)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pen-sun-03\\_2022+nm-turkish-yoke+freedom.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pen-sun-03_2022+nm-turkish-yoke+freedom.mp3)

Many times, a person loses something and after its loss, they realize they didn't realize lies what they had until it was lost. So it is with the freedoms we have now history shows in our current situation implies that there will be a day when we have less freedom. Are we living in a way that is truly free today? We use the readings of today to discuss the New Martyrs of the Turkish yoke and particularly the life of the holy martyr Timothy of Esphigmenou, how we should be living now to be ready for tomorrow.

Audio timestamps:

**1:48 - 4:51** How to get ready for persecution and difficulties, now while we have freedom.

**5:16 – 13:42** Life of Martyr Timothy of Esphigmenou

**12:27 - 13:42** Why should we read the lives of the martyrs, particularly those who apostatized, then repented?

**13:57 – 16:37** “And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to his purpose.” Rom 8:28

**16:37 – 17:47** “For whom he did foreknow, he also did predestinate to be conformed to the image of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brethren.” Rom 8:29

**17:47 – 21:34** “What shall we then say to these things? If God be for us, who can be against us?” Rom 8:31 And “For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, {39} Nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.” Rom 8:38-39

**21:43 - 23:25** “In your patience possess ye your souls.” Luke 21:19

**23:35 – 24:41** “The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light.” Matt 6:22

**24:41 – 25:36** We are free to desire anything we want, but if we desire something not of God, the Devil will always take something from us.

[New Martyr Timothy of Esphigmenou – a “false” apostate.](#)

Audio: [http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-10-29\\_2022+timothy-of-esphigmenou.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-10-29_2022+timothy-of-esphigmenou.mp3)

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/wC5hQ2b1zNg>

The life of my favorite New Martyr of the Turkish Yoke. Timothy became a “false” apostate – he feigned conversion to Islam in order to save his wife, and the story gets even more interesting from there. An excerpt, from a sermon entitled: [“The New Martyrs of the Turkish Yoke teach us how to use our freedom, against the day when we are not free”](#)

#### [A Christian reaction to the Supreme Court overturning of Row v Wade](#) Audio or Video

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc\\_2022+christian-reaction-to-roe-v-wade-overturn.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+christian-reaction-to-roe-v-wade-overturn.mp3)

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/W4CsJBG9W4k>

On the day after the historic overturning of Roe V Wade by the Supreme Court, we talk about the sober reaction a Christian must have to this news. It is never right to do something that is wrong. Overturning an immoral law is necessary, but NOT SUFFICIENT. We should not “celebrate” – we must increase our prayer. There is still a terrible amount of suffering.

Apologies about the recording quality. I made a mistake in recording. If I have time, I will edit the transcript and record again. This is a critical topic, and I did not want to let perfection be the enemy of the good (enough).

#### [Confession talk at St Iakavos camp: what, why, how?](#)

[http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism\\_2022-06-23+confession-talk-at-st-iakavos-camp.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2022-06-23+confession-talk-at-st-iakavos-camp.mp3)

Talk to youth at St Iakavos camp about confession, with Fr Seraphim and Sister Maxime. **WHAT** is it for, and what does the priest think of someone who confesses a terrible sin, and, **WHY** do we confess, **HOW** to prepare for it. And other stuff, such as what is the one thing in your life you cannot do without and why should we pray for anyone who harms us. IT is a lot, in about 25 minutes.

**0:09 – 8:16** What is confession for?

**8:25 – 11:29** Why pray for those who have harmed you, and how to pray for them.

**11:29 – 13:42** What to confess? Not a list of “things”; it is not “formal”. And about modern forms of confession that are not beneficial.

**13:42 – 18:27** How do you prepare for confession? Concentrate on who you are, and your relationships.

**18:35 – 22:03** What is one thing in your life you cannot do without?

**22:05 – 25:15** What does the priest think about someone if they confess a terrible sin? Will his opinion of the person be negative

**23:45 - 24:48** Sins of the flesh

#### [The message of Pentecost: "I will give you an heart of flesh ...and ye shall be my people, and I will be your God."](#)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost\\_2022+a-heart-of-flesh+ye-shall-be-my-people-and-i-will-be-your-god.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost_2022+a-heart-of-flesh+ye-shall-be-my-people-and-i-will-be-your-god.mp3)

A quick exegesis of the three Vespers Old Testament readings for Pentecost, with much lingering on the last, from Ezekiel 36:24-28. Herein is the message (result) of Pentecost: “A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh. ...and ye shall be my people, and I will be your God.”

8:41 the cure for a stony heart.

9:26 You must know that you can be a very bad person ... in order to become good. And 14:03 – 14:49

10:13 Ezekiel

#### [Pentecost: The appointed day of promise, and the fulfillment of hope.](#)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost\\_2022+the-appointed-day-of-promise-and-the-fulfillment-of-hope.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost_2022+the-appointed-day-of-promise-and-the-fulfillment-of-hope.mp3)

4:29 Commentary on the first hymn sung about Pentecost in the vigil: “We celebrate Pentecost, \* and the descent of the Spirit, \* and the appointed day of promise, and the fulfillment of hope. \* And such a mystery! Both great and venerable! \* Wherefore, we cry out unto Thee: \* O Lord, Maker of all things, glory to Thee! “ and a reflection on \*what\* the promise of Pentecost is, a promise unlike any other religion in the world. By Priest Nicholas Park

#### ["In a little while ... your heart shall rejoice, and your joy no man taketh from you." Can we wait?](#)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-wed-07\\_2022+in-a-little-while\\_john16-15-23.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-wed-07_2022+in-a-little-while_john16-15-23.mp3)

2022-06-08 13 minutes. Exegesis of John 16:15-23, especially noting the apparent and spiritual meaning of: “a little while.” Anything that is repeated in Scripture is important in this phrase is repeated five times. We also talk about the joy of the world which is as a psychotic laughing, and our joy, if we are can wait “a little while”. We also talk about what we know of the next life. The Lord tells us that

our sorrow will be turned into joy. He compares this joy to a woman who was given birth. If we understand even a little bit about this joy we will be able to wait "a little while."

Video: [New Martyr Alexander of Thessalonica +06-26-1794](#)

The New Martyr Alexander lived many years in deep apostasy before coming to his senses and being washed in the blood of martyrdom. His last hour alive on earth was very unique!

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/uo6PK0SDBdY>

[Christians live with the certainty that the future is in the present. High priestly prayer of Jesus Christ.](#)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07\\_2022+holy-fathers+live-as-if-the-future-is-the-present\\_john17-1-13.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07_2022+holy-fathers+live-as-if-the-future-is-the-present_john17-1-13.mp3)

Exegesis, with application to our lives, of the High Priestly prayer of Jesus Christ from John 17:1 through 13. We ask first why do we commemorate the fathers of the First Ecumenical Council and read this prayer on the Sunday before Pentecost? Then we go into all of the proofs that Jesus Christ is God and is completely equal to the Father, using the words of His prayer. And all of this must be applied! There are two applications. The first is that we must live in such a way that we are one with God since this is Jesus' prayer for us. We must understand what this means in order to live in this way. Our Lord also stated that He had completed the work that His Father had given him to do, even before He Jesus had been arrested and tried and crucified and all the rest. In chronological terms He had not completed the work but Christians live according to the future in the present. We talk about this at length. This is the only way to live especially in our troubled times when there will be many troubles coming. If we live only according to the present we will be lost if we live according to the future in our present, we will be saved. About 18min 2022-06-05

Partial (Audio) Timestamps.

0:17 – 1:28 Why commemorate the Fathers of the First Ecumenical council and read the high priestly prayer of Jesus Christ on the Sunday between Ascension and Pentecost?

1:28 – 7:27 All the parts of the High Priestly prayer of Jesus Christ which prove that He is God

3:53 – 4:17 "And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent" John 17:3

4:17 - 5:49 "And now, O Father, glorify thou me with thine own self with the glory which I had with thee before the world was" (John 15:5)

5:49 - 6:28 "Now they have known that all things whatsoever thou hast given me are of thee. 8 For I have given unto them the words which thou gavest me; and they have received them, and have known surely that I came out from thee, and they have believed that thou didst send me" (John 17:7-8)

6:28 – 6:46 "And all mine are thine, and thine are mine; and I am glorified in them." (John 17:10)

6:46 – 7:27 "Holy Father, keep through thine own name those whom thou hast given me, that they may be one, as we are" (John 17:11)

1:52 - 2:53 Why do we Orthodox stress so much the dogma that Jesus Christ is God and Man/ Why did 1000's of saints die to protect this dogma? What is the big deal?

5:01 – 5:41 We do not believe in "nice Jesus", as much of the so-called Christian world believes.

7:27 – 10:06 The APPLICATION of the dogma that Jesus Christ is one with the Father, and His prayer: "Holy Father, keep through thine own name those whom thou hast given me, that they may be one, as we are." And "these things I speak in the world, that they might have my joy fulfilled in themselves."

10:06 – end APPLICATION of Jesus' prayer: "4 I have glorified thee on the earth: I have finished the work which thou gavest me to do" (John 17:4)

[Fathers of First Council. "Who hath rent thy garment?"](#)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07\\_2022+fathers-of-first-council+who-hath-rent-thy-garment.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07_2022+fathers-of-first-council+who-hath-rent-thy-garment.mp3)

Fr Nicholas gives an exegesis of one of the hymns from Vespers in honor of the Holy Fathers of the First Ecumenical Council: "O My Savior, who hath thus rent Thy raiment? / Thou didst say: It was Arius / who sundered the Trinity's headship, / which is one in rank and honor. / That Thou art One of the Most Holy Trinity he disputed: / and he taught Nestorius the godless not to say Theotokos. / But the Council gathered in Nicaea / proclaimed that Thou, O Lord, art truly the Son of God, // one with the Father and the Spirit in rank." About 5 min. 2022-06-04